

EDGE To GPRS Fallback

An EDGE data card can offer high speed connectivity only within range of an EDGE tower. When the user moves into a neighbouring cell site that may not be EDGE-enabled, data access speeds "fall back" to GPRS levels.

networks that the Hutch data card offers GPRS roaming in, almost 18 are in the "Pre-Commercial" stage, which, according to the Hutch Web site, means one would not be charged for international roaming as of now.

The Next Step

Increased speeds will only come with 3G, which is yet to be rolled out in our country (see box 3G). In the US, EVDO (Evolution Data Only) and EVDV (Evolution Data Voice) 3G have offered real speeds of 180 to 300 kbps, with bursts of 500 kbps.

The GSM counterpart, EDGE, doesn't seem to be quite up to speed—100 to 130 kbps with bursts of 200 kbps. When Universal Mobile Telecommunications System (UMTS) succeeds GSM (see box UMTS), speeds of up to 2 Mbps are promised.

Is It For You?

From all we've talked about, you're probably not sure whether or not to opt for a data card. The

3G

A group of multinational wireless communications companies have banded together to develop and promote high-bandwidth third-generation (3G) wireless technology. The group, which goes by the name of 3G.IP, includes AT&T Wireless Services (now merged with Cingular), British Telecom, Ericsson, Lucent, Nokia, Nortel, Telenor AS, and Telecom Italia Mobile.

Mobile telephony and the Internet converged to create third-generation mobile services. The first commercial 3G service was rolled out by DoCoMo in Japan in 2001.

3G services combine high-speed mobile access with Internet Protocol (IP)-based services. Technologies such as W-CDMA (wide-band CDMA), CDMA-2000 and TD-SCDMA are deployed to enable access to information, media and entertainment, anytime, anywhere.

main factor is convenience—freedom from cables, disconnections, and so on.

Another issue is that of the price of the card itself: the table above (*Cost And Plan Charges*) should help you in your cost analysis.

Some also speculate that service providers might offer priority access to data card customers, since they would fall in the "business users" category. ■

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- IEEE 1394a (Fire Wire)
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- 7.1 channel; Realtek ALC880 header
- GbE LAN (Broadcom)
- IEEE 1394a (Fire Wire)
- 8 USB 2.0 ports



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